

# GOVERNORS-GENERAL

## GOVERNORS-GENERAL AND VICEROYS OF INDIA : SIGNIFICANT EVENTS IN THEIR RULE

### Governors-General I

#### 1. Warren Hastings 1773-1785

- (i) Regulating Act of 1773.
- (ii) Act of 1781, under which the powers of jurisdiction between the governor-general-in-council and the Supreme Court at Calcutta, were clearly divided.
- (iii) Pitt's India Act of 1784.
- (iv) The Rohilla War of 1774.
- (v) The First Maratha War in 1775-82 and the Treaty of Salbai in 1782.
- (vi) Second Mysore War in 1780-84.
- (vii) Strained relationships with Chait Singh, the Maharaja of Benaras, which led to Hastings' subsequent impeachment in England.
- (viii) Foundation of the Asiatic Society of Bengal (1784).

#### 2. Lord Cornwallis 1786-1793

- (i) Third Mysore War (1790-92) and Treaty of Seringapatam (1792).
- (ii) Cornwallis Code (1793) incorporating several judicial reforms, and separation of revenue administration and civil jurisdiction.
- (iii) Permanent Settlement of Bengal, 1793.
- (iv) Europeanisation of administrative machinery and introduction of civil services.

#### 3. Sir John Shore 1793-1798

- (i) Charter Act of 1793.
- (ii) Battle of Khadda between the Nizam and the Marathas (1795).

#### 4. Lord Wellesley 1798-1805

- (i) Introduction of the Subsidiary Alliance System (1798); first alliance with Nizam of Hyderabad.
- (ii) Fourth Mysore War (1799).
- (iii) Second Maratha War (1803-05).
- (iv) Took over the administration of Tanjore (1799), Surat (1800) and Carnatic (1801).

- (v) Treaty of Bassein (1802).

#### 5. Sir George Barlow 1805-1807

- Vellore Mutiny (1806).

#### 6. Lord Minto I 1807-1813

- Treaty of Amritsar with Ranjit Singh (1809).

#### 7. Lord Hastings 1813-1823

- (i) Anglo-Nepal War (1814-16) and the Treaty of Sagauli, 1816.
- (ii) Third Maratha War (1817-19) and dissolution of Maratha Confederacy; creation of Bombay Presidency (1818).
- (iii) Strife with Pindaris (1817-1818).
- (iv) Treaty with Sindhiya (1817).
- (v) Establishment of Ryotwari System by Thomas Munro, governor of Madras (1820).

#### 8. Lord Amherst 1823-1828

- (i) First Burmese War (1824-1826).
- (ii) Capture of Bharatpur (1826).

#### 9. Lord William Bentinck 1828-1835

- (i) Abolition of sati and other cruel rites (1829).
- (ii) Suppression of thugis (1830).
- (iii) Charter Act of 1833.
- (iv) Resolution of 1835, and educational reforms and introduction of English as the official language.
- (v) Annexation of Mysore (1831), Coorg (1834) and Central Cachar (1834).
- (vi) Treaty of 'perpetual friendship' with Ranjeet Singh.
- (vii) Abolition of the provincial courts of appeal and circuit set up by Cornwallis, appointment of commissioners of revenue and circuit.

#### 10. Lord Metcalfe 1835-1836

- New press law removing restrictions on the press in India.

#### 11. Lord Auckland 1836-1842

- (i) First Afghan War (1838-42).
- (ii) Death of Ranjit Singh (1839).

#### 12. Lord Ellenborough 1842-1844

- (i) Annexation of Sindh (1843).
- (ii) War with Gwalior (1843).

**13. Lord Hardinge I 1844-1848**

- (i) First Anglo-Sikh War (1845-46) and the Treaty of Lahore (1846).
- (ii) Social reforms including abolition of female infanticide and human sacrifice.

**14. Lord Dalhousie 1848-1856**

- (i) Second Anglo-Sikh War (1848-49) and annexation of Punjab (1849).
- (ii) Annexation of Lower Burma or Pegu (1852).
- (iii) Introduction of the Doctrine of Lapse and annexation of Satara (1848)/ Jaitpur and Sambhalpur (1849), Udaipur (1852), Jhansi (1853), Nagpur (1854) and Awadh (1856).
- (iv) "Wood's (Charles Wood, President of the Board of Control) Educational Despatch" of 1854 and opening of Anglo-vernacular schools and government colleges.
- (v) Railway Minute of 1853; and laying down of first railway line connecting Bombay and Thane in 1853.
- (vi) Telegraph (4000 miles of telegraph lines to connect Calcutta with Bombay, Madras and Peshawar) and postal (Post Office Act, 1854) reforms.
- (vii) Ganges Canal declared open (1854); establishment of separate public works department in every province.
- (viii) Widow Remarriage Act (1856).

**15. Lord Canning 1856-1857**

- (i) Establishment of three universities at Calcutta, Madras and Bombay in 1857.
- (ii) Revolt of 1857.

**Viceroy****1. Lord Canning 1858-1862**

- (i) Transfer of control from East India Company to the Crown, the Government of India Act, 1858.
- (ii) 'White Mutiny' by European troops in 1859.
- (iii) Indian Councils Act of 1861.

**2. Lord Elgin I 1862-1863**

Wahabi Movement

**3. Lord John Lawrence 1864-1869**

- (i) Bhutan War (1865)
- (ii) Setting up of the High Courts at Calcutta, Bombay and Madras (1865).

**4. Lord Mayo 1869-1872**

- (i) Opening of the Rajkot College in Kathiawar and the Mayo College at Ajmer for political training of Indian princes.
- (ii) Establishment of Statistical Survey of India.
- (iii) Establishment of Department of Agriculture and Commerce.
- (iv) Introduction of state railways.

**5. Lord Northbrook 1872-1876**

- (i) Visit of Prince of Wales in 1875.
- (ii) Trial of Gaekwar of Baroda.
- (iii) Kuka Movement in Punjab.

**6. Lord Lytton 1876-1880**

- (i) Famine of 1876-78 affecting Madras, Bombay, Mysore, Hyderabad, parts of central India and Punjab; appointment of Famine Commission under the presidency of Richard Strachey (1878).
- (ii) Royal Titles Act (1876), Queen Victoria assuming the title of 'Kaiser-i-Hind' or Queen Empress of India.
- (iii) The Vernacular Press Act (1878).
- (iv) The Arms Act (1878).
- (v) The Second Afghan War (1878-80).

**7. Lord Ripon 1880-1884**

- (i) Repeal of the Vernacular Press Act (1882).
- (ii) The first Factory Act (1881) to improve labour conditions.
- (iii) Continuation of financial decentralisation.
- (iv) Government resolution on local self-government (1882).
- (v) Appointment of Education Commission under chairmanship of Sir William Hunter (1882).
- (vi) The Ilbert Bill controversy (1883-84).
- (vii) Rendition of Mysore.

**8. Lord Dufferin 1884-1888**

- (i) The Third Burmese War (1885-86).
- (ii) Establishment of the Indian National Congress.

**9. Lord Lansdowne 1888-1894**

- (i) Factory Act (1891).
- (ii) Categorisation of civil services into imperial, provincial and subordinate.
- (iii) Indian Councils Act (1892).

- (iv) Setting up of Durand Commission (1893) to define the Durand Line between India and Afghanistan (now between Pakistan and Afghanistan).

#### 10. Lord Elgin II 1894-1899

Two British officials assassinated by Chapekar brothers (1897).

#### 11. Lord Curzon 1899-1905

- (i) Appointment of Police Commission (1902) under Sir Andrew Frazer to review police administration.
- (ii) Appointment of Universities Commission (1902) and passing of Indian Universities Act (1904).
- (iii) Establishment of Department of Commerce and Industry.
- (iv) Calcutta Corporation Act (1899).
- (v) Ancient Monuments Preservation Act (1904).
- (vi) Partition of Bengal (1905).
- (vii) Curzon-Kitchener controversy.
- (viii) Younghusband's Mission to Tibet (1904).

#### 12. Lord Minto II 1905-1910

- (i) Popularisation of anti-partition and Swadeshi Movements.
- (ii) Split in Congress in the annual session of 1907 in Surat.
- (iii) Establishment of Muslim League by Aga Khan (1906).

#### 13. Lord Hardinge II 1910-1916

- (i) Creation of Bengal Presidency (like Bombay and Madras) in 1911.
- (ii) Transfer of capital from Calcutta to Delhi (1911).
- (iii) Establishment of the Hindu Mahasabha (1915) by Madan Mohan Malaviya.
- (iv) Coronation durbar of King George V held in Delhi (1911).

#### 14. Lord Chelmsford 1916-1921

- (i) Formation of Home Rule Leagues by Annie Besant and Tilak (1916).
- (ii) Lucknow session of the Congress (1916).
- (iii) Lucknow pact between the Congress and Muslim League (1916).

- (iv) Foundation of Sabarmati Ashram (1916) after Gandhi's return; launch of Champaran Satyagraha (1916), Kheda Satyagraha (1918), and Satyagraha at Ahmedabad (1918).

- (v) Montagu's August Declaration (1917).

- (vi) Government of India Act (1919).

- (vii) The Rowlatt Act (1919).

- (viii) Jallianwalla Bagh massacre (1919).

- (ix) Launch of Non-Cooperation and Khilafat Movements.

- (x) Foundation of Women's University at Poona (1916) and appointment of Saddle's Commission (1917) for reforms in educational policy.

- (xi) Death of Tilak (August 1, 1920).

- (xii) Appointment of S.P. Sinha as governor of Bihar (the first Indian to become a governor).

#### 15. Lord Reading 1921-1926

- (i) Chauri Chaura incident (February 5, 1922) and the subsequent withdrawal of Non-Cooperation Movement.
- (ii) Moplah rebellion in Kerala (1921).
- (iii) Repeal of the Press Act of 1910 and the Rowlatt Act of 1919.
- (iv) Criminal Law Amendment Act and abolition of cotton excise.
- (v) Communal riots in Multan, Amritsar, Delhi, Aligarh, Arvi and Calcutta.
- (vi) Kakori train robbery (1925).
- (vii) Murder of Swami Shraddhanand (1926).
- (viii) Establishment of Swaraj Party by C.R. Das and Motilal Nehru (1922).
- (ix) Decision to hold simultaneous examinations for the ICS both in Delhi and London, with effect from 1923.

#### 16. Lord Irwin 1926-1931

- (i) Visit of Simon Commission to India (1928) and the boycott of the commission by the Indians.
- (ii) An All-Parties Conference held at Lucknow (1928) for suggestions for the (future) Constitution of India, the report of which was called the Nehru Report or the Nehru Constitution.

- (iii) Appointment of the Harcourt Butler Indian States Commission (1927).
  - (iv) Murder of Saunders, the assistant superintendent of police of Lahore; bomb blast in the Assembly Hall of Delhi (1929); the Lahore Conspiracy Case and death of Jatin Das after prolonged hunger strike (1929), and bomb accident in train in Delhi (1929).
  - (v) Lahore session of the Congress (1929); Purna Swaraj Resolution.
  - (vi) Dandi March (March 12, 1930) by Gandhi to launch the Civil Disobedience Movement.
  - (vii) 'Deepavali Declaration' by Lord Irwin (1929).
  - (viii) Boycott of the First Round Table Conference (1930), Gandhi-Irwin Pact (1931) and suspension of Civil Disobedience Movement.
- 17. Lord Willingdon 1931-1936**
- (i) Second Round Table Conference (1931) and failure of the conference, resumption of Civil Disobedience Movement.
  - (ii) Announcement of Communal Award (1932) under which separate communal electorates were set up.
  - (iii) 'Fast unto death' by Gandhi in Yeravada prison, broken after the Poona Pact (1932).
  - (iv) Third Round Table Conference (1932).
  - (v) Launch of Individual Civil Disobedience (1933).
  - (vi) The Government of India Act of 1935.
  - (vii) Establishment of All India Kisan Sabha (1936) and Congress Socialist Party by Acharya Narendra Dev and Jayaprakash Narayan (1934).
  - (viii) Burma separated from India (1935)..
- (iv) Resignation of Bose in 1939 and formation of the Forward Bloc (1939).
  - (v) Lahore Resolution (March 1940) by the Muslim League, demand for separate state for Muslims.
  - (vi) 'August Offer' (1940) by the viceroy; its criticism by the Congress and endorsement by the Muslim League.
  - (vii) Winston Churchill elected prime minister of England (1940).
  - (viii) Escape of Subhash Chandra Bose from India (1941) and organisation of the Indian National Army.
  - (ix) Cripps Mission's Cripps Plan to offer dominion status to India and setting up of a Constituent Assembly; its rejection by the Congress.
  - (x) Passing of the 'Quit India Resolution' by the Congress (1942); outbreak of 'August Revolution'; or Revolt of 1942 after the arrest of national leaders.
  - (xi) 'Divide and Quit' slogan at the Karachi session (1944) of the Muslim League.

#### **19. Lord Wavell 1944-1947**

- (i) C. Rajagopalachari's CR Formula (1944), failure of Gandhi-Jinnah talks (1944).
- (ii) Wavell Plan and the Shimla Conference (1942).
- (iii) End of Second World War (1945).
- (iv) Proposals of the Cabinet Mission (1946) and its acceptance by the Congress.
- (v) Observance of 'Direct Action Day' (August 16, 1948) by the Muslim League.
- (vi) Elections to the Constituent Assembly, formation of Interim Government by the Congress (September 1946).
- (vii) Announcement of end of British rule in India by Clement Attlee (prime minister of England) on February 20, 1947.

#### **20. Lord Mountbatten 1947-1948**

- (i) June Third Plan (June 3, 1947) announced.
- (ii) Introduction of Indian Independence Bill in the House of Commons.
- (iii) Appointment of two boundary commissions under Sir Cyril Radcliff for the partition of Bengal and Punjab.

#### **18. Lord Linlithgow 1936-1944**

- (i) First general elections (1936-37); Congress attained absolute majority.
- (ii) Resignation of the Congress ministries after the out-break of the Second World War (1939).
- (iii) Subhash Chandra Bose elected as the president of Congress at the fifty-first session of the Congress (1938).